

Retrieving Lost Passwords

What happens if you forget your password? If you have an account at Indiatimes or Geek, it's pretty simple to retrieve it...so simple that even others could probably do it and use your account without your knowledge. Indiatimes asks for minimal information during registration, and the only password retrieval option is the hint question, which most people tend to keep as 'the city where you were born' or 'your pet name'. All an intruder would have to do is enter some random name, hope the hint question is one of the above, and if he gets the answer right (after all some Rajesh or Vidya would hail from Mumbai) the password flashes on his screen. Indiatimes does have an option for providing a hint question of your choice, but most people we guess do not use this at all.

The difference with other sites such as Myrealbox or Geek that also use the hint question method is that instead of displaying the original password on screen they reset it. One of the strongest password retrieval securities you will find is at Email.com. In the event that you forget your password, Email asks for details such as your name, last name, date of birth and also an alternative e-mail address. Only then does it move to the hint question. Based on your responses to all of these, a message is sent to the alternative e-mail address either informing you that your password has been reset or that the details were incorrect. Also, an intruder would not be able to try out different combinations, since Email shows a message that the last attempt was just a

minute earlier. It even reports the unauthorised request to your mailbox.

Sites such as Yahoo.co.in are so paranoid that they don't even allow you to change your birth date or the hint question once you have registered. While Hotmail is somewhat similar to Yahoo!, the only difference is that it doesn't ask for your birth date, but makes do with your

Email.com: A tough nut to crack

place of residence as specified in the registration. If you have problems even with this, you can e-mail Hotmail and based on their reply, send details about your last login, birth date, region etc, and it e-mails a new password back to you. Excite was the only site that presented you with a hint question, without requiring an answer, at the time of registration. If you were to forget your password the site asks for your birth date and pincode. After delivering the right answers, you are then presented with the hint question, which should hopefully help you recollect the password. Alternatively, if you've provided another e-mail address during registration, it e-mails a new password to you at that address.

Follow these simple steps to safeguard your password:

- Keep your password complex. Most sites do not have password limitation criteria (minimum six characters, etc), but you should have passwords that are a combination of words and numbers, in both upper and lower case.
- Remember the information you entered during registration. Most of us hate filling forms, and therefore enter whatever we feel like. Nothing wrong with that, but just try and ensure that you enter information regarding your birth date, country, region, pin code etc correctly. This information is mostly used during password retrieval.
- Let your hint question be as difficult as possible. Remember that most of your friends or relatives may know everything about you, so your hint question should be one that even they wouldn't have an answer to. Avoid using hint questions such as the city you were born in. It won't take much guesswork to crack that! Use something like the last four digits of your credit card instead.
- Preferably, if you have an alternative e-mail address, fill the field for current or alternative e-mail address during the registration process
- If the site offers secure login or asks you whether you are on a shared or public computer, select it. This ensures that the password is encrypted. Secure logins, however, do tend to be a bit slower, so be patient.
- Don't check the 'Remember password on my computer' option, unless you are the only user at the computer.

formatting, etc. Hotmail and Yahoo.co.in also provide for adding emoticons to the message (you can use these features even in your signature), while Indiatimes comes with an option of adding a table, but we couldn't for the life of us figure out what you'd want to use it for.



Compose rich text at Indiatimes.com

Is there a best?

The e-mail service you use also depends, to a large extent, on the popularity of the provider and the assurance that they will be around for a long time to come.

While there's no way anyone can predict whether the service will exist tomorrow or not, we at least feel safer with a Hotmail or Yahoo! address because of the trust factor, than a Geek address (where, incidentally, we even managed to register linus@geek.com!). But if you combine the various features including the speed, registration process, storage space etc, you'd find Hotmail to be the overall best, even with a 2 MB storage space. It really scores in terms of features and combines a strong anti-spam feature, not to mention its sleek new design. You got e-mail now!

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